

Ready, Set, Go!



To the trinitarian, Christ Jesus is true God and True Man; But to his mother, Mary – he was her child whom she carried within her womb, birthed, nurtured, worried over, and raised to manhood. As a child do you think Christ was this stoic figure, we tend to create to separate Christ from us and elevate above us? Or do you see, young Jesus, running about, laughing, and playing with the other kids in the community?

In the Jewish communities all over the world and throughout time, you can hear children laughing together as they play and even dare one another shouting, “shalosh arba ve,”. Its literal translation is: “three, four and...” – the closest equivalency we have in English is the call to action: “ready, set, go!”

The call to action could be as simple as skipping rope, racing up a hill of dirt, or doing the daring things that we did as kids; the very things that we laughed about until we realized that our mothers were scared enough to unfurl their hidden capes and leap into action in order to save us from our own fearlessness.

How many times can you imagine Christ uttered that same children’s expression, “shalosh arba ve!” How many times can you imagine that the child Jesus answered the challenge set forth by his friends who urged him on with the plea, “Ready, Set, Go!”?

God chose the life of Christ. He chose to have the full human experience. He was not born to privilege or wealth, and nobility. He was not raised in a reputable family. He grew up in a poor household among simple people. His community was governed by religious laws and under foreign secular rule. As a child of that community, he would have played the same games that all the other children played.

This peculiar expression, raises another question; Why not one, two, three? Why not start at one? Why do they start at three, give the number four, then say the word and is if to encourage you to continue on with the count?

We are left to contemplate the meaning of three. The number three suggests a pattern of completeness. It symbolizes seeds, trees, fruit, revelation, gathering, balance, equilibrium, patterns, counsel, witness, strength, resurrection, and new life.

Within the symbol of the seed, itself, unlocks one of the early Christ mysteries. The seed must be released from the ovule; where the seed is buried, dies, and is resurrected to bring forth new life. Here, even the cycle of life, the trinity completes and perpetuates itself. The number three becomes that singular state of perfection and has many representations throughout time.



Primally, there were three states of being in the natural world: Liquid, gas, and solid. In our own span of existence, there are three principal stages of life: infancy, adulthood, and old age. In a panic attack, three controlled deep breathes can bring a person back to a point where they can begin self-government and self-management. In life, you can create an environment of positivity and success by saying aloud, 3 positive affirmations each day.

In the life of a Masonic Candidate, three knocks can change his entire life for the better. There are three principal Officers of a: Lodge, Chapter, Council, and Commandery. In symbolic Masonry, three degrees take a man and create him into a Brother. In the life of a Master Mason, once he becomes a member, there are three bodies within the York Rite that he may choose to join; and within the life of a Sir Knight, there are three Orders which are conferred upon him. This cannot be merely coincidence, but by design. If not by the authors of our ritual, than it is the design of the Supreme Author and Architect. For it is written, “...the things which are impossible with men are possible with God.” (Luke 18:27)

The number three, appears 467 times in the King James Bible. Three brings harmony and unity to opposites like one and two. It creates a solid or a foundation and makes one of the primary geometric shapes: the triangle. Is there any question in your mind, therefore, that the triangle become one of the earliest representations and emblems for God? Each side of that triangle being a representation of the natural attributes of God: Omniscience, Omnipotence, and Omnipresence.

The sequence of three makes a chain of continuity:

Before the flood, there were three righteous patriarchs; namely Abel, Enoch, and Noah. Upon those waters subsiding and the world replenishing itself again, three more patriarchs came forth: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Moses ascended and descended Mount Sinai three times and God’s laws were gifted unto us.

There were three kings of a united Israel: Saul, David, and Solomon. As the prophecies began to be fulfilled in Christ, it would be three magi, or scholars – who traveled from three kingdoms each bearing gifts to pay homage to the infant Jesus.

Melchior the Persian scholar, Balthazar the Babylonian scholar, and Caspar a scholar who was believed to hail from Indo-Asia or Africa - traveled a great distance to kneel before a child born in a stable. They brought gifts fit for a king in the form of gold, frankincense, and myrrh. Each gift offers us a unique symbol within the Christ mysteries. Gold recognized the authority of Christ the King. Frankincense, a sweet-smelling incense, was used by the high priests as a burnt offering and prayer to God; this was given in recognition of the divinity of Christ. Myrrh was used to anoint kings and as an embalming oil for those most respected and cherished of our departed loved ones; this foreboding gift recognized the coming mortality and martyrdom of our savior.

Not much is known about the childhood of Christ. We know that Mary and Joseph raised Jesus. We know that God commanded Mary to flee to Egypt and there to take refuge from King Herod. We know that Joseph was a carpenter who raised Jesus to be of the same profession.

In accordance with their customs, Mary and Joseph take Jesus up to the temple in Jerusalem by age 12. Mary begins the journey home and discovers Christ missing from her care. For three days Jesus remains at the temple not just speaking to the elders and the priests; but rather teaching them. When Mary asks Him why? Lovingly, Jesus reassures her with, “How is it that you sought me? Did you not know that I must be about my Father’s business?” This ends his infancy, he is now **ready** for adulthood.

Over the next 18 years of the life of Jesus, it is said that he grew in wisdom, stature, and in the favor of God and man.



The trinity is present at the Baptism of Christ. In the Gospel of Matthew 3:16-



17 we read: “And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway out of the water: and, lo, the heavens were opened unto him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him: And lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.” Here we see God the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

Christ goes into the wilderness to fast for forty days and nights, where the devil tempts him three times. In the first temptation, the body weak from hunger, the devil tempts Christ make bread out of stones to relieve his own hunger. In response, Christ quotes Deuteronomy saying, “... It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.”

In the second temptation, the devil takes Jesus to the Holy City and places him upon the pinnacle of the highest tower. Counting on fear to consume Christ, the devil taunts Him to throw himself off the tower and count on the Angels of the Lord to break his fall and prevent any harm to come to Jesus. Once again, Christ quotes Deuteronomy saying, “... It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God.”

With the third temptation the devil takes Christ up to the highest mountain where all the kingdoms could be seen. Counting on the greed of man, the Devil offers Christ the dominion over all the kingdoms of the world if only he would bow down and worship him. Once more the Laws aide him, when Christ quotes Deuteronomy for a third time - saying, “...Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve.”

By the third decade of life, Jesus began His ministries. As a carpenter, and a fisherman, Christ now enters His third profession as a teacher and rabbi bringing the Gospel of truth the His message of Love.

Throughout His ministry John the Evangelist, Andrew, and Simon Peter would be among the first three called upon to become Disciples. Nine more would follow numbering the twelve apostles of Christ. The message of His ministry was **set** in motion.

Before His hour had arrived, in the Gospel of Mark, there were three incidences where Christ instructed that the truth of his identity be kept secret, and not yet revealed. The first was to unclean spirits Christ rebuked. The Second was to the people he had healed in his early ministry. The third was to his disciples on the road to Caesarea and Phillipi.

Three times in the Gospel of Matthew Christ warns us about the hypocrite – (an ancient Greek word that means thespian, or actor):

Christ instructs us how to be genuine and sincere when he said, “do not sound a trumpet before thee, as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and in the streets, that they may have glory of men...” He continues to instruct you that your charity and generosity should be given in secret, so much so that as Jesus sates: “...let not thy left hand know what thy right hand doeth”

In order to develop an honest relationship with God, Christs said, “When you pray, you are not to be like the hypocrites; for they love to stand and pray in the synagogues and on the street corners so that they may be seen by men. Truly I say to you, they have their reward in full.” He continues to teach us on how to develop that open relationship with God by saying, “when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret.”

Christ instructs us even in the observance of a religious fast when he states, “...be not, as the hypocrites, of a sad countenance: for they disfigure their faces, that they may appear unto men to fast. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward.” He continues to say how to fast when he says, “... anoint thine head, and wash thy face; That thou appear not unto men to fast, but unto thy Father which is in secret.”

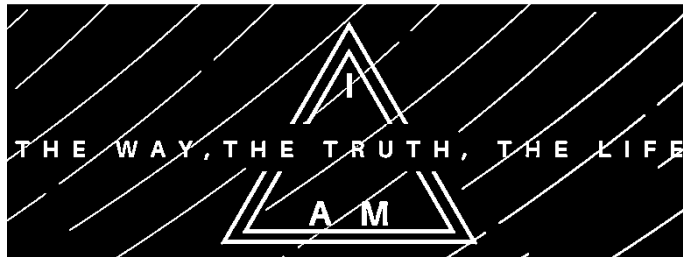
Christ defined the three great Commandments when He said, “Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.” And in the Gospel of John , we receive the third commandment, when Jesus said, “A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another. By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.”

Christ instructs us how to become a disciple when he said, “... Whosoever will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me.”

1. Deny himself

2. Take up his cross
3. Follow me.

Christ defines salvation when He proclaims, “I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.”

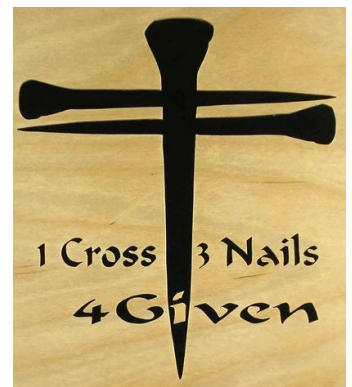


Before his betrayal and arrest, Jesus prayed three times in the Garden of Gethsemane. For bringing the world His message of truth, and of Love, Christ, in the third year of His ministries was arrested, held to three trials:

The first court held by Sanhedrin was under the darkness of night; the second trial of Jesus was at Pilate's court, then He was brought briefly before the court of Herod Antipas.

During the first of Christ's trials, Peter is humbled. Before the third rooster crows, Peter denies Christ three times.

Christ suffers being abducted, mocked, and scourged before he is crucified. Jesus was placed on the cross at the third hour of the day (9 a.m.). Three nails would change the course of humanity for all time, as they were driven through Christ where he was crucified on a cross, that has been described in some accounts, as tau shaped or a tree.



The title: “Jesus of Nazareth King of the Jews” was written in three languages: Hebrew, Greek, and Latin – and placed upon the Cross of Christ.



Three were crucified on that day: Christ Jesus and two criminals. There were 3 hours of darkness that covered the land while Jesus was suffering on the cross from the 6th hour to the 9th hour; and at the 9th hour or 3p.m. Christ uttered 3 words – saying, “... It is finished.” Then he bowed his head, and gave up the ghost.

According to the Gospel of John, at the Cross was John (who was also known as James), and 3 Women named Mary: Mary mother of Jesus, Mary Magdalene, and Mary of Cleophas.

Christ was dead for three full days and nights. Here we discover the miracle of the Resurrection. Christ conquers death and brings forth life eternal in the Father.

After his resurrection, Christ gives Simon Peter another lesson. The Risen Christ, upon his third appearance to his disciples, asks Peter three times “ Simon Peter, Simon, son of Jonas, do you love me?” and each time Peter answered, “Yes Lord, I love you.”

Forgiven, and redeemed, Christ commanded.
“Then feed my sheep.”

Jesus, repeated this not twice, but three times. It was as if, he was challenging a childhood friend; daring Peter to step up and continue what they began together. As if Christ was saying, Okay, Peter.. “shalosh arba ve,”.... “Ready, Set, Go!”- **Go** and make disciples of the world. **Go** and Love one another as I have loved you... **Go** and feed my sheep. Go and care for my flock.



This is the true lesson of the resurrection. In Christ, we can be forgiven and redeemed. Through Christ, we can know the Father. In Christ, we can seek salvation.

We are all Children of the same Almighty Father. As Children, we are expected to learn and to grow; and so, I say to each of you here: “shalosh arba ve,”
- **Ready, set, Go!**

Go in peace, to love and serve the Lord!

In the name of the Father, and the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen!

Fraternally Submitted,

SK William E. McCraw

Generalissimo

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